

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 127

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Thiamine (vitamin B1), easy to under-eat without noticing

"Thiamine helps your body turn food into usable energy, drawn from whole grains, legumes, nuts and seeds — for most people eating a varied diet it's simple to get enough, though sustained heavy alcohol use, a history of bariatric surgery, or prolonged vomiting can raise the risk of falling short."

Why it matters now

Thiamine (vitamin B1) helps your body convert carbohydrates, fats and protein into usable energy, and supports normal nerve function. It's found across many everyday foods — whole grains, legumes, nuts and seeds, with smaller amounts in eggs and dairy — so a varied plate covers it for most people without any deliberate tracking. There's no established Tolerable Upper Intake Level for thiamine, and no toxicity has been documented from ordinary food intake. That reflects an absence of documented harm from food, not a guarantee that any dose of supplementation is safe — high-dose thiamine supplementation still isn't something to take without a reason.

Sustained heavy alcohol use, a history of bariatric surgery, and prolonged vomiting are examples of situations that genuinely raise the risk of falling short, not an exhaustive list — each can reduce how much thiamine your body absorbs or retains. This week's meals follow the same varied pattern this series encourages throughout.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you've had bariatric surgery: malabsorption of certain nutrients, including thiamine, is a recognised risk after some procedures — routine monitoring and supplementation guidance from your surgical or medical team should already account for this; this series' general meal suggestions don't replace that plan.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still

hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Sikkimese home cooking (momos, thukpa noodle soup, and fermented preparations like gundruk, sinki and kinema, drawn from Nepali, Bhutia and Lepcha communities). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Thiamine (vitamin B1) helps your body convert the carbohydrates, fats and protein you eat into usable energy, and supports normal nerve function. It's found across many everyday foods — whole grains, legumes, nuts and seeds, with smaller amounts in eggs and dairy — so a varied plate through the week covers it for most people without any special planning.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Gundruk-tempered vegetable stir-fry with whole wheat roti and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 2 roti) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with a vegetable thukpa, noodle soup with a measured 1/2 cup cooked noodles and mixed vegetables (1 cup broth) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Kinema, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked kinema) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi
- B. Chicken momos, steamed dumplings with a tomato-sesame chutney (6 pieces, approx 100g chicken filling) and a cucumber salad

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted sunflower seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Whole grains carry more of it than heavily milled ones

Whole grains — unpolished or hand-pounded rice, whole wheat, millets like kodo or finger millet — retain more thiamine than heavily milled, polished grains. You don't need to switch what you usually eat; folding in a whole grain a few times a week is a simple way to broaden your sources.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Kodo millet upma with vegetables and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup upma) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable thukpa, noodle soup with scrambled egg and a measured 1/2 cup cooked noodles (2 eggs, 1 cup broth) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Sinki, fermented radish-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Sikkimese-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Vegetable-and-lentil khichdi with spinach (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies)
- B. Chicken curry, Sikkimese-style (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — A note on alcohol and absorption

A history of bariatric surgery and a stretch of prolonged vomiting are two more examples of situations worth mentioning to your clinician for the same reason — both can lower how much thiamine your body takes in or keeps.

Worth knowing: Sustained heavy alcohol use is a well-established risk factor for thiamine deficiency — it can both reduce how much your body absorbs and often coincides with lower overall food intake. If it applies to you, or you have questions about your own drinking, your clinician can help — thiamine deficiency is treatable once identified.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Buckwheat dhido, porridge (a measured 1/2 cup cooked buckwheat, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-tomato wrap, scrambled egg in a whole wheat roti (2 eggs, 1 roti) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Kinema, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked kinema) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

B. Chicken thukpa, noodle soup with chicken, vegetables and a measured 1/2 cup cooked noodles (100g chicken, 1 cup broth) with a side salad

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Cooking methods that help it survive the pot

Thiamine is water-soluble and breaks down with prolonged heat, so it's easy to lose some in cooking. Using the cooking water in a dish rather than draining and discarding it, and not overcooking vegetables and legumes, are simple habits that help hold onto a bit more of it — nothing to track precisely.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Gundruk-tempered vegetable stir-fry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Vegetable-and-paneer momos, steamed dumplings (6 pieces, approx 100g paneer filling) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

B. Egg curry, Sikkimese-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi

B. Gundruk-chicken curry, fermented greens with chicken (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — An easy whole-grain swap, not a rule

Swapping in a whole grain — millet, whole wheat, unpolished rice — for a refined one at one meal today is an easy way to add thiamine and fibre together, if it's convenient. It isn't a rule to follow every day, and your usual rice-based meals remain a perfectly fine base the rest of the time.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Finger millet (ragi) roti with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils and vegetables (2 roti, 1 cup dal-vegetable mix) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Sinki, fermented radish-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Sikkimese-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rajma-and-vegetable pulao (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

One meal heavy in refined grains, or one day without a dedicated whole-grain dish, doesn't meaningfully change your thiamine status — it's the pattern of varied foods across the week, not any single plate, that matters here.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Gundruk-tempered vegetable stir-fry with cabbage and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with capsicum (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Kinema, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked kinema) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Sikkimese-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Gundruk-tempered vegetable stir-fry with whole wheat roti and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 2 roti) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Boiled eggs (2) with a vegetable thukpa, noodle soup with a measured 1/2 cup cooked noodles and mixed vegetables (1 cup broth) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Kinema, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked kinema) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

B. Chicken momos, steamed dumplings with a tomato-sesame chutney (6 pieces, approx 100g chicken filling) and a cucumber salad

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted sunflower seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi

B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, was there a whole grain or preparation you hadn't tried before that you'd keep making room for?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- Source fermented preparations like gundruk, sinki and kinema from a reliable maker or reputable brand, and prepare them according to package or recipe instructions.
- Sustained heavy alcohol use, a history of bariatric surgery, and prolonged vomiting are examples of situations that raise the risk of thiamine deficiency — mention any of these to your clinician if they apply to you. There's no established upper intake level for thiamine from food, but that reflects limited data on high-dose supplementation, not a guarantee that any dose is safe — don't self-prescribe a high-dose thiamine supplement without a reason.

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Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 128

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Vitamin E, where more isn't automatically better

"Vitamin E is an antioxidant found in nuts, seeds, vegetable oils and leafy greens — these foods contribute vitamin E without needing to track it. High-dose vitamin E supplements are a different matter: they can raise bleeding risk, particularly with anticoagulant or antiplatelet medicines, so check the combined amount across any supplements you take with your pharmacist."

Why it matters now

Vitamin E is a fat-soluble antioxidant that helps protect your cells from everyday oxidative damage. It's found across nuts, seeds, vegetable oils like sunflower and safflower, and leafy greens — a varied diet with some nuts, seeds or oil-based cooking helps most people meet their needs without any deliberate tracking, and dietary deficiency on its own is genuinely rare.

High-dose vitamin E supplements can increase bleeding risk, particularly if you take an anticoagulant or antiplatelet medicine. This isn't limited to a supplement taken on its own — the combined amount across a multivitamin and any separate vitamin E product can add up, so it's worth checking the total with your pharmacist. There's an established upper intake level for vitamin E, but staying under it isn't a guarantee of safety for everyone. Ordinary food sources don't carry this concern.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you take a blood thinner, aspirin or another antiplatelet medication, or have upcoming surgery: check the combined amount of vitamin E across everything you take — including a multivitamin — with your pharmacist, and don't start a high-dose vitamin E supplement without your clinician's guidance; it can raise bleeding risk in this situation. Vitamin E from food isn't a concern.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Rampuri and Rohilkhandi cooking (the Rampur region of western Uttar Pradesh) — mild Nawabi kormas finished with a cashew-almond gravy, seekh kebabs, and nut-forward dals. If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Vitamin E is a fat-soluble antioxidant that helps protect your cells from everyday oxidative damage. It's found in nuts, seeds, vegetable oils like sunflower and safflower, and leafy greens — most people eating a varied diet with some nuts, seeds or oil-based cooking get enough without any special effort.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable korma, mixed vegetables in a cashew-almond gravy with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup korma) with roti (2 pieces) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with sunflower-seed paratha (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rampuri dal, spiced lentils finished with a nut-and-cream tempering (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken Rampuri korma, almond-and-cashew gravy (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with roasted sunflower seeds (15g)
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer Rampuri korma (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Everyday sources, without needing a supplement

A tablespoon of sunflower or safflower oil used in cooking, a small handful of almonds or sunflower seeds, or a serving of spinach or another leafy green all add up across the week — vitamin E doesn't usually need a dedicated dish or a supplement on top of a varied diet.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Spinach-and-lentil paratha (2 pieces, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-spinach bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rampuri dal with a nut-and-cream tempering (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi
- B. Seekh kebab, minced chicken skewers (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Chicken Rampuri korma (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — If you take a high-dose vitamin E supplement

A multivitamin's vitamin E content on its own is usually modest, but added to a separate high-dose supplement — often marketed for skin, hair or antioxidant claims — the total can add up quickly. Check the combined amount rather than assuming a multivitamin is automatically fine to add another product on top of.

Worth knowing: High-dose vitamin E supplements can increase bleeding risk, particularly if you take an anticoagulant or antiplatelet medicine. This applies to the combined amount across everything you take, not only a standalone vitamin E product — a multivitamin and a separate supplement both count toward the total. There's an established upper intake level for vitamin E, but staying under it isn't a guarantee of safety for everyone. If you take any vitamin E supplement at a meaningful dose, check the combined amount with your pharmacist.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable korma with cashew-almond gravy and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup korma) with roti (2 pieces) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Rampuri-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Masoor dal khichdi with mixed vegetables (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked masoor dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies)
- B. Paneer-and-beans curry, paneer with french beans and tomato (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Cooking oil is already doing some of the work

The vegetable oil you already cook with contributes vitamin E, especially sunflower, safflower or wheat-germ oil — you don't need a special oil just for this, but it's worth knowing your everyday cooking already helps.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sunflower-seed-and-vegetable upma with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup upma) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Mutton Rampuri korma (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Chicken Rampuri seekh, spiced minced chicken skewers (100g minced chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — An easy nut-and-seed addition, not a rule

Adding a small handful of almonds, sunflower seeds or another nut or seed to one snack today is an easy way to add vitamin E alongside other nutrients — it isn't something to do at every meal, and your usual snacks the rest of the week are fine as they are.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils and vegetables (1 cup dal-vegetable mix) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rampuri dal with a nut-and-cream tempering (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi
- B. Seekh kebab, minced mutton skewers (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates and roasted almonds (15g)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

One meal without any nuts, seeds or oil-cooked vegetables doesn't meaningfully change your vitamin E status — it's the pattern of varied foods across the week, not any single plate, that matters here.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable korma with cashew-almond gravy and peas and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup korma) with roti (2 pieces) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with onion (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rampuri dal with a nut-and-cream tempering (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Chicken Rampuri korma (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable korma, mixed vegetables in a cashew-almond gravy with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup korma) with roti (2 pieces) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with sunflower-seed paratha (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rampuri dal, spiced lentils finished with a nut-and-cream tempering (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken Rampuri korma, almond-and-cashew gravy (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with roasted sunflower seeds (15g)
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer Rampuri korma (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, did you notice your everyday cooking oil, nuts or seeds already doing some of this work without you planning for it?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- Vitamin E from food is not a bleeding concern. High-dose supplementation is a different matter, especially alongside a blood thinner, aspirin or another antiplatelet medication, or ahead of surgery — check the combined amount across any supplements you take with your pharmacist before adding one.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 129

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Reading a nutrition label — what's actually worth your attention

"A nutrition label is a tool to reach for occasionally, not a test to pass at every meal — knowing where to look (serving size, the ingredient list, allergen statements) tells you more than a marketing claim on the front of the pack ever will."

Why it matters now

Reading a nutrition label well is a practical skill, not a test to pass — knowing where to look and what actually matters can make choosing between two packaged foods, or deciding whether something fits your usual pattern, a lot quicker. It's a tool to reach for occasionally, not a habit to maintain at every meal.

This week isn't about restricting packaged food or treating it as automatically worse than home-cooked — plenty of packaged foods fit comfortably into a varied diet. The goal is simply knowing how to read what's actually on the label, so a marketing claim on the front doesn't do the deciding for you.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or

another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Dawoodi Bohra home cooking, a Gujarati Muslim community cuisine — dal chawal gosht, kheema, sev khatta, vegetable kharo and Bohra-style cutlets. If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

In India, check first whether the numbers on a label are given per 100 g/ml, per serving, or for the whole pack — FSSAI's labelling rules allow information per 100 g/ml or for a single-consumption pack, and an imported product may follow a different convention again. Knowing which basis you're looking at before comparing two products is the single most useful habit for reading a label accurately.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Masoor dal, Bohra-style with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup dal, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with a Bohra-style chutney sandwich (2 slices bread) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable khari, spiced vegetable stew (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Dal chawal gosht, mutton simmered with lentils (100g mutton, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Bohra-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Ingredients are listed by weight, not by importance

Ingredients are listed in order by weight, from most to least — glancing at the first three or four tells you what a food is mostly made of, and where added sugar sits in that list gives a sense of how prominent it is. That's different from the quantitative added-sugar figure on the nutrition panel itself, which states the actual amount — the two tell you different things, and it's worth checking both rather than treating one as more informative than the other. Added sugar also goes by many names (sucrose, high-fructose corn syrup, cane juice, several others ending in "-ose"), so recognising a few of these helps you read the ingredient list accurately alongside the figure.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sev khatta, tomato-and-sev curry with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup curry) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Bohra kheema-stuffed paratha (100g minced chicken, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable khari with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup khari, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Bohra cutlet, spiced minced mutton patties (100g mutton, 2 cutlets) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Bohra-style (100g fish) with roti (2 pieces) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Checking the allergen line, every time

Allergen statements aren't the only safety-relevant part of a label — storage instructions and the use-by or best-before date matter too, especially once a pack is opened. Most of the rest of this week is about making shopping a bit easier, not about avoiding packaged food.

Worth knowing: Allergen statements on packaged food ("contains," "may contain traces of") are there for a genuine safety reason — if you or someone you're cooking for has a known food allergy, checking this line specifically, every time, including on a product you've bought before, is worth the extra few seconds. Formulations do change.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Masoor dal, Bohra-style with spinach and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup dal, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

B. Dal chawal murgh, chicken simmered with lentils (100g chicken, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer Bohra curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — %Daily Value is a reference point, not a personal target

Indian packaged food often shows %RDA (Recommended Dietary Allowance) rather than the %DV (Daily Value) figure used on some imported labels — the two are calculated differently and aren't directly comparable. Either way, the percentage is based on a general reference intake, not your own individual needs — it's a rough way to compare one food to another, not a personalised target to hit exactly at every meal.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Vegetable khari with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup khari, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Bohra kheema-stuffed paratha (100g minced mutton, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

B. Bohra-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Toor dal khichdi with cauliflower (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked cauliflower; add water as needed, finished volume varies)

B. Bohra cutlet, spiced minced chicken patties (100g chicken, 2 cutlets) with roti (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — A front-of-pack claim isn't the whole story

Some front-of-pack claims, like "no added sugar," have defined conditions under FSSAI rules — but meeting that definition doesn't mean a food is sugar-free (it can still contain natural sugars) or automatically suitable for a diabetes meal plan. Other claims, like "natural" or "made with real fruit," aren't defined as precisely. Either way, a quick glance at the ingredient list behind the claim is the more reliable check.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sev khatta, tomato-and-sev curry with peas and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup curry) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable khari with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup khari, 1 cup rice) and a bottle-gourd sabzi
- B. Dal chawal machhi, fish simmered with lentils (100g fish, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — An occasional tool, not a habit for every meal

You don't need to read every label on every item every time — it's a tool to reach for occasionally, when you're curious or deciding between two similar products, not a habit to maintain at every single meal. The one exception is managing a known food allergy, where checking the allergen line on each purchase, every time, is worth keeping up regardless.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Masoor dal, Bohra-style with carrots and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup dal, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with capsicum (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable khari with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup khari, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Bohra-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Bohra-style paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Masoor dal, Bohra-style with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup dal, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with a Bohra-style chutney sandwich (2 slices bread) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kharo, spiced vegetable stew (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Dal chawal gosht, mutton simmered with lentils (100g mutton, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Bohra-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, is there one packaged food you buy regularly that you'd like to actually check the label on next time?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- On packaged food, always check the allergen statement ("contains" / "may contain traces of") if you or someone you're cooking for has a known food allergy — check every time, even on a product you've bought before, since formulations can change. Storage instructions and the use-by or best-before date are also safety-relevant, especially once a pack is opened.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 130

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Riboflavin (vitamin B2), a steady everyday nutrient often taken for granted

"Riboflavin helps your body turn food into energy and supports normal vision and skin — found across dairy, eggs, leafy greens, almonds and mushrooms, it's one of the easier nutrients to get enough of, and even a bright-yellow tinge to your urine from a supplement is a harmless, well-known effect, not a cause for concern."

Why it matters now

Riboflavin (vitamin B2) helps your body convert food into usable energy, and supports normal vision and healthy skin. It's found across dairy, eggs, leafy greens, almonds and mushrooms — a varied plate helps most people meet their needs without any deliberate tracking. There's no established upper intake level for riboflavin from food, and no toxicity has been documented from ordinary intake — that reflects an absence of documented harm, not a guarantee that any dose of supplementation is safe.

A diet that includes very little dairy, egg or other animal-source food — a strictly vegan diet, or one shaped by a milk allergy, lactose intolerance or another exclusion — is one recognised risk factor for falling short, and fortified plant foods and a wider mix of legumes, nuts and greens are worth leaning on if that describes you. This week's meals follow the same varied pattern this series encourages throughout.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Saoji and Varhadi cooking (Vidarbha, eastern Maharashtra, centred on Nagpur) — fiery Saoji chicken and mutton curries alongside vegetarian Varhadi staples like zunka, vangi bharit and patodi rassa. If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Riboflavin (vitamin B2) helps your body convert food into usable energy, and supports normal vision and healthy skin. It's found across dairy, eggs, leafy greens, almonds and mushrooms — a varied plate through the week covers it for most people without any special planning.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zunka, besan-based dry curry with roti and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup zunka, 2 roti) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Patodi rassa, gram-flour dumplings in a spiced gravy (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Saoji chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer, Saoji-style curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Everyday sources, spread across the day

Dairy, eggs, leafy greens, almonds and mushrooms all carry riboflavin — spreading a couple of these across your day, rather than relying on just one, is an easy way to cover it without any special planning.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Varhadi vangi bharit, roasted eggplant mash with roti and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup bharit, 2 roti) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-mushroom bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Patodi rassa with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup rassa, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Saoji mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Saoji chicken curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — A harmless, well-known supplement effect

You don't need to watch for this or worry about it — it's included here only because it can be a surprising thing to notice if nobody's mentioned it before.

Worth knowing: If you take a B-complex or riboflavin supplement, a bright yellow tinge to your urine can be a harmless colour change from the riboflavin itself — riboflavin is water-soluble, and your body simply clears what it doesn't use. That explains the colour, but it doesn't by itself mean every ingredient in a B-complex product is safe at any dose, or that any urine colour change is automatically harmless — if you notice a change you're unsure about, or take a high-dose product, it's worth mentioning to your clinician or pharmacist.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zunka with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup zunka, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Varhadi-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-beans curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — If your diet includes very little dairy or egg

A diet that includes very little dairy, egg or other animal-source food — including a strictly vegan diet, or one shaped by a milk allergy, lactose intolerance or another exclusion — is a genuine, worth-naming risk factor for lower riboflavin intake. Leafy greens, almonds, mushrooms, legumes and fortified plant milks or cereals are the foods actually doing the work here if that describes you; checking labels for fortification helps.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Varhadi vangi bharit with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup bharit, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Saoji mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Saoji-style egg curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Keeping milk out of direct light, a small kitchen habit

Riboflavin breaks down with light exposure more than with heat — keep perishable milk refrigerated as usual, and where practical choose an opaque container or keep it away from direct light too, as an addition to refrigeration rather than a substitute for it. It's a small habit, not something to be precise about.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils and vegetables (1 cup dal-vegetable mix) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Patodi rassa with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup rassa, 1 cup rice) and a bottle-gourd sabzi
- B. Saoji chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

One meal without any dairy, eggs or leafy greens doesn't meaningfully change your riboflavin status — it's the pattern of varied foods across the week, not any single plate, that matters here.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zunka with rice and carrots and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup zunka, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with capsicum (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Patodi rassa with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup rassa, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Saoji mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal khichdi with squash (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked squash; add water as needed, finished volume varies)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Zunka, besan-based dry curry with roti and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup zunka, 2 roti) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Patodi rassa, gram-flour dumplings in a spiced gravy (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Saoji chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Paneer, Saoji-style curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, did knowing about the harmless urine-colour effect change how you think about a B-complex supplement you already take, if you take one?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- If you take a B-complex or riboflavin supplement, a bright yellow tinge to your urine can be a harmless colour change from your body clearing the excess riboflavin — but that alone doesn't confirm every ingredient in the product is safe at any dose. Mention a supplement or a urine change you're unsure about to your clinician or pharmacist.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 131

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Choosing and reusing cooking oil, safely and without waste

"The oil you cook with is part of your everyday fat intake — choosing a suitable unsaturated oil, matching it to the cooking method, and avoiding repeated reuse of frying oil are small, practical habits, not a case against fried food altogether."

Why it matters now

Choosing a suitable unsaturated cooking oil for your everyday meals, matching it to the cooking method, and storing oil sealed and away from heat and light are small, practical habits. Rotating between more than one oil across the week can add some variety if convenient, but it isn't something you need to aim for — owning several oils isn't a requirement.

If you deep-fry, there's one genuine safety habit worth knowing: repeatedly reheating and reusing the same batch of oil can break it down and form compounds linked to health risks with regular exposure. FSSAI's guidance for Indian kitchens is to avoid reusing frying oil repeatedly. This isn't a case against fried food — it's specifically about how many times the same oil gets reused before it's discarded.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Kongunadu cooking (Coimbatore and the western Tamil Nadu plains) — nattu kozhi (country chicken) curry, kola urundai (fried-then-simmered meatballs), kandarappam rice pancakes and vegetable kootu. If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

The oil you cook with is part of your daily fat intake, and different oils carry different mixes of saturated, monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fat. Choosing a suitable unsaturated oil (sunflower, groundnut, mustard, rice bran, and others) for your everyday cooking matters more than which specific one you use — rotating between more than one oil across the week can add some variety if it's convenient, but owning several oils isn't something you need to aim for.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Arisi paruppu sadam, rice-and-lentil dish with peas and carrots (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with kandarappam, savoury rice pancakes (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kootu, mixed vegetable-and-lentil stew (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Nattu kozhi curry, country chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts and ellu podi, sesame powder (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Kola urundai, fried-then-simmered meatball curry (100g minced chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Matching the oil to the heat

Different oils, and different levels of refinement of the same oil, have different smoke points — the temperature at which they start to break down and smoke — so oil type and refinement both matter; the same name (like olive oil) can behave quite differently depending on how refined it is. Rather than memorising specific temperatures, the simpler habit is: choose an oil suited to the cooking method you're using, follow the label's guidance if it gives one, and avoid heating any oil until it's smoking.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Ragi kali, finger millet porridge with spinach (a measured 1/2 cup cooked ragi, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion kandarappam, savoury rice pancakes with egg (2 eggs, 2 pieces) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kootu with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup kootu, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Kola urundai, fried-then-simmered meatball curry (100g minced mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Nattu kozhi curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Reusing frying oil, safely

This isn't about avoiding fried food altogether — it's a specific habit around how many times the same batch of oil gets reused.

Worth knowing: Repeatedly reheating and reusing the same oil for deep frying, especially at high temperatures, can break it down and form compounds linked to health risks with regular exposure. FSSAI's guidance for Indian kitchens is to avoid reusing frying oil repeatedly, rather than following a fixed number of reuses — discarding oil after each fry is the safer habit where practical. If oil is reused at all, strain out food particles, store it covered, keep reuse to a minimum, and discard it immediately if it's darkened, thickened, foams up, smells off, or starts smoking at a lower temperature than before.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Arisi paruppu sadam with beans (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-tomato omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

B. Fish curry, Kongunadu-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-beans curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Ordinary, well-stored oil works just as well

An ordinary, everyday cooking oil stored properly — sealed, away from direct heat and light — holds up just as well as an expensive specialty oil for most home cooking. You don't need anything exotic for this week's meals to work.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Vegetable kootu with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup kootu, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

B. Nattu kozhi curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi

B. Chicken chettinad, Kongu-style pepper chicken curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — An easy oil swap, not a rule

Swapping in a different oil than usual for one dish this week — if you happen to have more than one at home — is a simple way to add variety. It isn't a rule to follow every day, and your usual oil the rest of the week is a perfectly fine choice.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils and vegetables (1 cup dal-vegetable mix) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kootu with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup kootu, 1 cup rice) and a bottle-gourd sabzi
- B. Nattu kozhi curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one dish

One meal that's fried rather than steamed or simmered doesn't meaningfully change things on its own — enjoying fried food occasionally is completely fine. Keep that separate from the oil-reuse habit from earlier this week, though: how many times a batch of frying oil gets reused is its own safety question, worth keeping to a minimum regardless of how often you fry.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Ragi kali with cabbage (a measured 1/2 cup cooked ragi, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with capsicum (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kootu with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup kootu, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Kongunadu-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Muttai masala, spiced egg curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Arisi paruppu sadam, rice-and-lentil dish with peas and carrots (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Boiled eggs (2) with kandarappam, savoury rice pancakes (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Vegetable kootu, mixed vegetable-and-lentil stew (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

B. Nattu kozhi curry, country chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts and ellu podi, sesame powder (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi

B. Kola urundai, fried-then-simmered meatball curry (100g minced chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, is there a habit around your frying oil — how you store it, how many times you reuse it — you'd like to change?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- FSSAI advises avoiding repeated reuse of frying oil — discarding it after each fry is the safer habit where practical. If oil is reused, strain it, store it covered, keep reuse to a minimum, and discard it immediately if it's darkened, thickened, foams up, smells off, or smokes at a lower temperature than before.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 132

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Nutrition-related health checks worth keeping on your radar

"A handful of nutrition-related terms — iron, vitamin B12, vitamin D, thyroid function — sometimes come up in routine bloodwork this far into postpartum life; knowing what they're for helps you follow the conversation with your own clinician, not a checklist to schedule on your own."

Why it matters now

A handful of nutrition-related terms — iron, vitamin B12, vitamin D, thyroid function — sometimes come up in routine bloodwork this far into postpartum life. This week is a brief, plain-language reminder of what each is for, pointing back to this series' own dedicated week on the topic where one exists, so the vocabulary is familiar if your clinician raises it.

This isn't a testing schedule or a self-diagnosis tool — which checks make sense for you, and when, is a judgment your own clinician makes based on your history and symptoms, not something this series can or should decide for you.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If it's been a while since your last routine bloodwork: mention any fatigue, hair changes, or other symptoms to your clinician, who can decide whether checking iron, B12, vitamin D or thyroid function makes sense for you specifically — this series doesn't set a testing schedule.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Andaman Islands home cooking, as prepared by the Bengali, Tamil, Telugu and Karen settler communities who make up most of the islands' population — coconut-based curries, fresh seafood, and tropical produce like tapioca, jackfruit and banana flower. If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

This week isn't about ordering tests for yourself — it's about recognising a few nutrition-related terms your clinician might mention, so the conversation makes sense if and when it comes up. None of this replaces your own care team's judgment about what's relevant for you specifically.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Tapioca-and-vegetable stew with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stew) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Jackfruit curry, coconut-based (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Coconut fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Chicken coconut curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Iron, and why it can still be catching up

This far into postpartum life, iron deficiency isn't automatically something to attribute to childbirth — it can persist, resolve, or develop fresh for unrelated reasons, and heavy bleeding at delivery or closely spaced pregnancies are examples of risk factors, not an explanation on their own. Fatigue alone isn't a reliable sign either way — it's worth having assessed when it's indicated by your symptoms or history, not assumed one way or the other. If your clinician suggests checking, it's a simple blood test, and food choices alone don't replace a supplement if one's indicated. This series covered iron in its own dedicated weeks earlier on.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Banana-flower stir-fry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Tapioca-and-vegetable stew with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stew, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Prawn coconut curry (100g prawns) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Andaman-style chicken pepper fry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Vitamin B12, especially on a vegetarian or vegan diet

Dairy and eggs contribute B12, but eating them doesn't automatically guarantee adequate levels — absorption problems, which become more common with age and can affect anyone regardless of diet, are a separate route to low B12 that a plant-based diet alone doesn't explain and eating animal-source food alone doesn't rule out. Unusual fatigue, tingling or numbness, or other new symptoms are worth mentioning to your clinician regardless of what you eat.

Worth knowing: If you eat little or no animal-source food, vitamin B12 is a genuinely useful one to ask your clinician about — this series covered it in its own dedicated week, and it isn't something food alone reliably covers on a strict vegetarian or vegan diet.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Jackfruit curry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup curry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi
- B. Chicken coconut curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer coconut curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Vitamin D, a quick reminder

This series also covered vitamin D in its own dedicated weeks — worth a brief reminder here since it's one of the more commonly checked nutrition-related labs. Routine testing isn't automatically needed for otherwise healthy adults taking ordinary amounts; it becomes more relevant if a deficiency is suspected or already diagnosed.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Tapioca-and-vegetable stew with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stew, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken coconut curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Egg-and-coconut curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Thyroid function, if your history includes it

If you had a thyroid condition identified during pregnancy or postpartum, ongoing monitoring is usually already part of your care plan — this series covered eating well through a postpartum thyroid swing in its own dedicated week. If you haven't had a thyroid diagnosis, new or persistent symptoms — unusual fatigue, weight change, hair or mood changes, among others — can still be worth discussing with your clinician; a previous diagnosis isn't a requirement for raising the conversation.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils and vegetables (1 cup dal-vegetable mix) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Jackfruit curry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup curry, 1 cup rice) and a bottle-gourd sabzi
- B. Chicken coconut curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — These checks follow your own history, not a fixed schedule

None of this week's mentions are things this series is telling you to schedule — they're here so the terms are familiar if your clinician raises them, based on your own history and symptoms, not a generic postpartum checklist everyone follows the same way.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Banana-flower stir-fry with drumstick and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with capsicum (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Tapioca-and-vegetable stew with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stew, 1 cup rice) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Chicken coconut curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Tapioca-and-vegetable stew with a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stew) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Jackfruit curry, coconut-based (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Coconut fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a rajma (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Chicken coconut curry (100g chicken) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back across this run of weeks, is there a nutrition-related term from this week you'd feel more confident asking your clinician about now?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish and prawns from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook them fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- Nutrition-related labs (iron, B12, vitamin D, thyroid) are ordered based on your own symptoms and history by your clinician — this series doesn't set a testing schedule or diagnose based on symptoms alone.